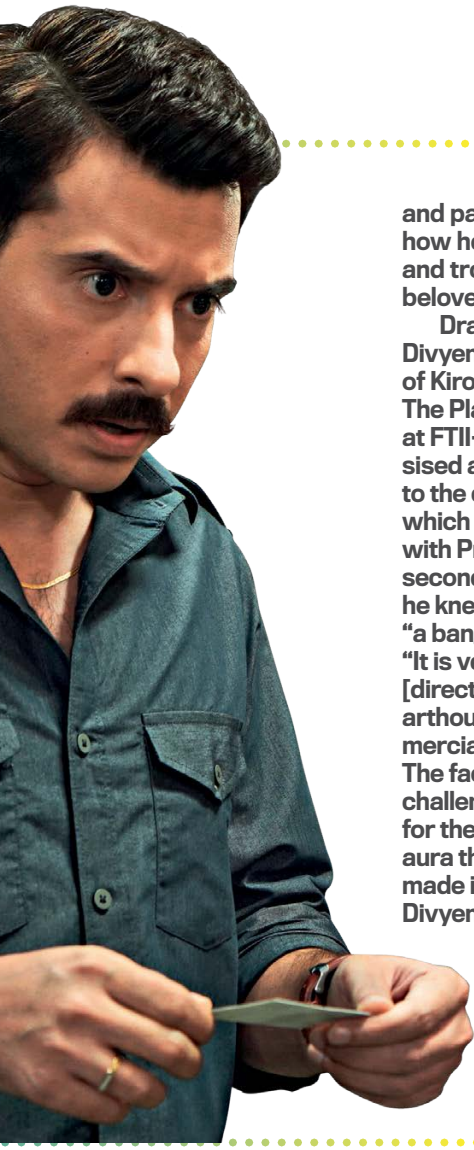


and passive or dry comedy." That's how he managed to make the dark and troubling Munna one of the most beloved characters of OTT.

Drama, on the other hand, is more Divyenndu's space, having been a part of Kirori Mal College's theatre group, The Players, and then studying acting at FTII–both of which emphasised a realistic approach to the craft. With *Agni*, which sees him team up with Pratik Gandhi for the second time this year, he knew he had read "a banger" of a script. "It is very *kadak*, it's got [director] Rahul Dholakia's arthouse flavour with a commercial element," he says. The fact that the role entailed the challenge of playing a Maharashtrian for the first time and embodying the aura that comes with donning the khaki made it all the more interesting. Says Divyenndu, "In some characters, the external [side] is very important. Here, the way I carry myself, look and talk–the physicality–matters."

It further helped that the film is produced by Farhan Akhtar and Ritesh Sidhwani's Excel Entertainment, which over the years has become Divyenndu's happy space given the plum parts they have offered him in *Mirzapur* and *Madgaon Express*. "I have always enjoyed the cinema they come up with. You don't have to worry because there are already filters and standards," he says.

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Divyenndu joins fellow FTII alums like Jaideep Ahlawat, Vijay Varma and Rasika Dugal whose professional trajectory got a fillip with the rise of streaming platforms. "It has educated our audiences on how to relish different genres," he says. "Filmmakers have become much more confident in taking risks with different subjects and experimenting with actors [to cast]." The timing couldn't have been better as he had waited for "the perfect entry" whilst declining "boy-next-door, comic parts". It came at a cost, though. "People don't appreciate it when you say no." Then came the blockbuster that was *Mirzapur*. Having a level playing field is all that Divyenndu needs to shine. ■

–Suhani Singh

country offered Sharma pause. "With non-fiction, I realised that I am looking at the world outside as a filmmaker," Sharma tells INDIA TODAY over a phone call. "Maybe that's why I could feel the desire to make fiction so strongly, because there was a lot of information that I was soaking in but there was very little that I was speaking from inside."

So, for her next project, Sharma decided to go within. This year, she wrote, directed, and co-produced *Gagan Gaman*, marking her return to fiction storytelling after seven years. Set in Jaipur, the filmmaker's hometown, the 30-minute short is beguiling and unsettling in equal measure. Steeped in Rajasthani folklore, the film follows a newlywed woman's quest for personal freedom in a narrative that playfully pairs surrealism with the reality of being a woman.



"I have always had this idea of making a film in Jaipur where I could explore the quotidian aspect of the city," Sharma explains of the starting point. "Jaipur is often celebrated as a tourist-friendly city and depicted in films often for its beauty. But I was interested in capturing the darker side of the city." Awash with vivid sound and imagery that pay attention to the oral storytelling subcultures of northern India, *Gagan Gaman* continues Sharma's preoccupation with making sense of her roots.

After its world premiere at the MAMI Mumbai Film Festival, Sharma pitched *Gagan Gaman* at Film Bazaar—the project market that runs concurrently with the International Film Festival of India—in Goa. She doesn't seem too fussed about its outcome, saying, "I see this film as a conversation starter for my feature." She is aware of the precarious realities of filmmaking, especially as someone who, by her own admission, got boxed as a documentary filmmaker. For her, *Gagan Gaman* was meant to be an investment in her own craft. For now, her job as a filmmaker is done. ■

–Poulomi Das